



FRANCE BORDERS SEVEN OTHER COUNTRIES—Spain, Andorra, Italy,

FRENCH

AN APPRECIATION OF THE GOOD LIFE

Switzerland, Luxembourg, Belgium, and Germany—and is only separated from the United Kingdom by the English Channel. The French people

THE ROLE OF RELIGION

France has been a secular country since the time of the French Revolution, so there is no national religion, nor is religion taught in schools. Many people belong to the Roman Catholic church, and France is also home to many Muslims who have emigrated from North Africa.



WINE PRODUCTION

The French have been producing wine since at least Roman times. Wines from each region taste different thanks to a variety of factors including the type of grape, climate, soil, and the way the wine is fermented.



Free time

Quality of life and leisure time are very important to the people of France. All French workers are entitled to five weeks of paid vacation annually, and many take the entire month of August off. They decamp to the countryside to vacation homes or hotels, leaving the cities virtual ghost towns.



TRADITIONAL PASTIME

Boules, or *pétanque*, is a popular French game played with metal balls. The goal of the game is to get your ball as close as possible to the target ball known as the *cochonnet*. Players are also allowed to throw their balls at the *cochonnet* so as to nudge it farther from their opponents' balls and closer to their own.

